

Heraldry
Heraldic devices, such as the shields displayed by this 15th-century knight in the *Codex capodilista*, were both a military status symbol and a mark of social standing.

Knights broadly fitted into the system of personal loyalty and mutual obligation that shaped medieval society. They might, for example, owe military service as vassals or liegemen to a lord or king in return for a grant of land held as a fief – the classic pattern of the "feudal" system. But in the later Middle Ages monetary arrangements progressively came to the fore. Whether knights lived on their own land or as retainers in a noble household, by the 14th century they would expect to be paid for their services, even though the service was recognized as a feudal obligation. By the same token, they could often pay money in lieu of service – shield tax or "scutage".

CHIVALRY AND GLORY

Medieval society thoroughly encouraged young males of social standing to seek glory in war. They were provided with role models both in fiction – as in the Arthurian legends or the French "chansons de geste" – and in tales of the feats of contemporary real-life heroes such as England's Black Prince or Bertrand du Guesclin, the constable of France. The Church sanctified the practice of war, at least if directed against "infidels" or in some other just cause, and the code of chivalry established principles of conduct that a knight should follow.

Chivalry incorporated many of the usual principles of warrior morality, such as loyalty to your leader or to your brothers-in-arms, together with Christian-derived values such as respect for the poor and needy. But the chivalric code was also a practical arrangement between knights to limit the risks of warfare. Being of the same rank and often related by blood or marriage, opposing knights had an interest in avoiding a fight to the death. If they were facing defeat, they could usually surrender in the confident expectation of being treated well as prisoners and eventually ransomed – although there were exceptions to this rule, as when the English King Henry V ordered the killing of French prisoners at Agincourt in 1415.

Ransoms could be considerable sums of money, so there was obviously a profit motive at work in the preservation of prisoners' lives. However much knights might be inspired by the prospect of honour and glory, they usually also had material goals in sight. Many knights were far from wealthy. They might hold fiefs that were small plots of land similar to those worked by peasant families, or they could be younger sons with no expectation of an inheritance. Skill in the use of arms gave a man a chance to better himself. He could forge a distinguished military career, as Bertrand du Guesclin did from unpromising provincial origins, or win lands through participating in conquest, as happened during the Crusades.



Horse armour
The warhorse was the knight's most expensive – and vital – piece of equipment. Horse armour, such as this 15th-century German shaffron (head plate), helped protect mounts in battle or during jousts.

PRINCIPLES AND PROFIT

Some knights joined military orders, swearing allegiance to the master of the order and fidelity to their companions. These orders, often an elite among the knighthood, were either religious like the Templars, Hospitallers, or Teutonic Knights –

EVOLUTION OF THE KNIGHT

The evolution of European knights' helmets and body armour from the 11th to the 16th century reflected advances in the technology of metalworking, but also the changing status of the knight. At the start of the period he was a rough-and-ready fighting man in the service of a great lord or ruler; by its end the knight had a prestige and self-importance that generally outweighed his practical function on the battlefield.

The basic armour of the knight in the 11th century was the hauberk, a coat of chainmail – knee-length, short-sleeved, and with a hood (or coif) to protect the head and neck. Over this hood the knight wore his helm, a cone of iron with a nosepiece as the sole protection for the face. The limitations of mail are evident in the fact that knights still carried shields to ward off blows.

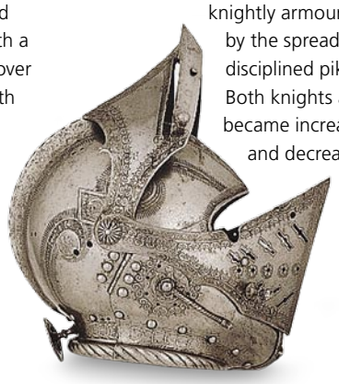
In the following centuries, sections of plate were added to the chainmail, spreading from vulnerable points such as the lower legs, arms, and shoulders to cover the entire body, including the feet, by around 1400. The head received maximum protection, with a steel cap worn under the mail coif and over it a flat- or round-topped helmet with a visor covering the face. The anonymity of this outfit was countered by wearing identifying plumes on helmets or cloth surcoats – the latter also serving to cool the metal in hot sun. From the 15th century onwards, plate armour was at its most elaborate. Metalworkers in Milan and Augsburg produced engraved suits of armour that were luxury works of art, intended primarily for tournaments. Meanwhile the battlefield function of knightly armour was undermined by the spread of firearms and disciplined pike-wielding infantry. Both knights and their armour became increasingly decorative and decreasingly effective.



10th-century helm
This Wenceslas-style helm is forged from a single piece of iron with an added nasal guard. Body armour of the period would be mainly chainmail.



14th-century basinet
Full plate armour only gradually replaced chainmail. This Italian basinet combines a mail collar with a removable conical plate visor.



16th-century armet
Helmets and armour reached the height of their magnificence in the 16th century, fashions growing increasingly elaborate as the knight's battlefield role declined.